

Why People Move: The Great Migration

Grades 5–8 · Social Studies

THE 35 MINUTES

5 min	10 min	15 min	5 min
HOOK	TEACH	ACTIVITY	CLOSING

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

What students will understand

Students will analyze the causes and consequences of the Great Migration (1910–1940), evaluate primary source evidence including maps, photographs, and personal testimonies, understand how demographic shifts shape culture and politics, and connect historical migration to present-day patterns of movement.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

NCSS Standard II (Time & Continuity)	Analyze cause-and-effect relationships in historical events; evaluate the significance of historical turning points
NCSS Standard III (People, Places, Env.)	Understand how physical and human geographic factors influence migration and settlement patterns
CCSS.ELA-LITERACY RH.6-8.1	Cite specific textual evidence to support analysis of primary and secondary sources

MATERIALS

- Exhibition's Great Migration Map (physical or virtual — minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance)
- Optional: Jacob Lawrence's *Migration Series* images (free to view on the Phillips Collection and MoMA websites)
- Differentiated student handouts

HOOK · 5 MINUTES

Why do people move?

Ask students to brainstorm: what reasons might cause people to leave their homes? Collect responses on the board without comment. Then reveal: between 1910 and 1940, over one million Black Americans left the South — the largest internal migration in American history at that time.

"Every migration in history has push factors — reasons people leave — and pull factors — reasons they're drawn somewhere new. The Great Migration had both. Today we're going to investigate what those were, trace the routes people took, and understand what happened when they arrived."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · 10 MINUTES

"The push factors were brutal. Jim Crow laws enforced racial segregation in every area of life. The sharecropping system trapped Black families in debt they could never escape. Lynching was used as a tool of terror. The Ku Klux Klan was resurging. Black veterans returned from WWI to find the country they fought for still treated them as less than citizens."

"The pull factors were powerful. Northern factories needed workers — World War I had cut off European immigration while demand for labor surged. Black newspapers like the Chicago Defender actively recruited Southern readers, publishing stories of higher wages, better schools, and relative freedom. Word spread through churches and community networks: go north."

"When migrants arrived in Harlem, they didn't find paradise — they found overcrowded housing, discrimination in employment, and a Northern racism that was less explicit but no less real. What they also found was each other. A community dense enough to support Black-owned newspapers, theaters, churches, restaurants, and eventually — the Harlem Renaissance."

Show the Great Migration Map from the exhibition. Walk through the six cities — Mississippi Delta, New Orleans, Memphis, St. Louis, Chicago, Harlem — and the changes at each stop.

ACTIVITY · 15 MINUTES

GREEN LEVEL
MORE SUPPORT

Students complete a push/pull factors chart, label cities on the migration map, and write three sentences explaining why families made the journey.

YELLOW LEVEL
GRADE LEVEL

Students analyze a primary source document (a letter, newspaper excerpt, or photograph from the exhibition) using the SOAPS method, then write a paragraph evaluating it as historical evidence.

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

Students research and compare two waves of the Great Migration (1910–1940 and 1940–1970), analyze why the second wave occurred even after the Harlem Renaissance, and evaluate what "success" meant for the movement as a whole.

CLOSING

"The Harlem Renaissance happened because people refused to let injustice silence them. They used every form of expression available to them — music, poetry, painting, movement, story — to say: we are here, we are extraordinary, and we will not be erased. That courage lives in every lesson you take from this work."

Exit ticket: *"Name two push factors and two pull factors of the Great Migration. Then name one thing that was different about the North from what migrants expected."*

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit the exhibition: If the Harlem Renaissance exhibition is available at your school, visit the Mini Museum to experience the phonograph, Jazz Lab, Great Migration Map, and more. Ask your librarian to arrange a class visit.

Option 2 — Virtual visit: minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

Paintings to project (in copyright, so not printed; each title links to the museum's page): Jacob Lawrence, The Migration Series (1940–41)